

Chapter 77_1 - Enough

After their conversation ended and they walked out of the alley, when they turned the corner, Ning Fuyi caught a whiff of clear gardenia fragrance. She quietly moved her nostrils.

Looking up, she saw Chu Qingqiu standing with Jiuying and the others by the street, watching several children play with flower lanterns.

"Finished talking? Then let's go." Chu Qingqiu said indifferently, then moved gracefully and disappeared into the crowd, with the others following.

Ning Fuyi was at the back. She turned to look back at the pitch-black alley - the floral fragrance in the air had already been scattered by the wind, but she was certain she had truly smelled its presence.

Her smooth fingertips thoughtfully played with her Thought Pearl as she stood there for a while, then turned to follow the others.

The night in the mortal world seemed like a stolen moment of pleasure in the midst of busyness. The moment they stepped into Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, they were again faced with various matters that left them physically and mentally exhausted.

The heads of the four great families had gathered at Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate under the pretext of discussing demon elimination, but in reality, they had been secretly invited by Chu Qingqiu to assist her in performing the Waning Moon Array¹.

In the afternoon, in the meeting hall of Jingshan Palace, Chu Qingqiu stood at the main seat, holding a remnant scroll in her hands as she looked at the four family heads seated respectfully.

The four great families were: Xiangshan Liu Clan, Wushan Jiang Clan, Tianshan Jin Clan, and Guangling Gongsun Family. The head of the Jiang Clan had been bedridden for years, so large and small affairs had been taken over by Jiang Li.

"Qiuyi, serve tea." Chu Qingqiu said softly. Qiuyi, standing behind her, nodded and stepped forward to direct several immortal attendants to pour tea for each person.

After the attendants closed the doors and left, Liu Family Head Liu Wenhai cupped his hands and smiled: "Since we parted in Qi Kingdom, I haven't seen the Divine Venerable again. I wonder what matter brings the Divine Venerable to summon us here?"

"Liu Wenhai, the Divine Venerable summoning us must be related to demon subjugation. Who doesn't know that the six realms are not peaceful now, with demons causing trouble everywhere? Even my Guangling, located in the prosperous mortal realm, has suffered many demonic disasters, let alone your little Xiangshan." Gongsun Family Head Gongsun Mo swirled his teacup, arrogantly blowing away the foam on top.

"Bah! What do you know, you black monkey? Though my Xiangshan isn't as large as your Guangling, it's still a crucial hub in the mortal world. I'm asking the Divine Venerable - what business does a black monkey like you have in this?" Liu Wenhai stroked his beard, retorting sarcastically.

"I naturally have no objection to you asking the Divine Venerable, but I never expected that after all these years, you'd still be such a sycophant." Gongsun Mo smiled slightly, tilted his head back to drink his tea, and made a satisfied clicking sound.

"You monkey, how dare you..."

"Enough, enough! I say, you two have been arguing for decades with the same few lines over and over. When will you be done?" Jin Clan Head Jin Yan shook her head. She put down her teacup. "The Divine Venerable is still here - don't lose your composure."

Only then did Gongsun Mo and Liu Wenhai close their mouths. They glared at each other once more before stopping.

"Aunt Jin still has a way with them." Jiang Li covered her lips and smiled.

Jin Yan looked at her kindly, with a trace of pity in her eyes: "Since that incident, I haven't seen little Jiang for several years. How is your grandmother now?"

The smile on Jiang Li's face faded slightly, then she answered: "Grandmother is still bedridden and refuses to see me."

Hearing this, Jin Yan let out a long sigh.

"Let's not chat about family matters - the Divine Venerable is still waiting." Jiang Li smiled brightly again, turning to Chu Qingqiu who sat steadily. "Divine Venerable, please speak your mind."

Seeing that they were all finally looking at her, Chu Qingqiu began: "Patriarch Gongsun's guess is correct. I have indeed summoned you all for demon elimination, requesting your assistance."

"You must have all heard about how Liu Family Head's daughter Liu Wenzhu was captured by demons and nearly lost her life some time ago." Chu Qingqiu glanced at Liu Wenhai, whose expression suddenly changed, then continued: "After that incident, the demon clan will certainly not let matters rest. They will definitely take advantage of the current chaos in the Eastern Wasteland and the weakness of the immortal sects to make a comeback."

"If we cannot stop them when that time comes, it won't just be Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate that's destroyed - it will endanger all corners of the world. That's why I've asked everyone to join me in performing the Waning Moon Array."

Upon hearing this, several people looked at each other, all seeing shock in each other's eyes. Among them, Jiang Li was most shocked. She clenched her fists as if to say something, but seeing Chu Qingqiu's gaze, she barely restrained herself.

Instead, her expression changed to one of worry.

"The Waning Moon Array? The formation the Divine Venerable used to slay the ancient evil spirit?" Liu Wenhai swallowed hard. "How can our immortal power compare to the Divine Venerable's? We..."

"Liu Wenhai, if you're afraid, just say you're afraid. We know you've always been cowardly and greedy for life, so we won't laugh at you." Gongsun Mo parted his ink-black hair and smiled.

"Who says I'm afraid? The demon clan kidnapped my daughter! How could I be cowardly and greedy for life? You're the one spouting nonsense, you black monkey - you're probably the afraid one!" Liu Wenhai was practically jumping up to confront Gongsun Mo.

Gongsun Mo looked at Liu Wenhai disdainfully, then stood up and nodded proudly to Chu Qingqiu: "We all understand what the Divine Venerable has said. I, Gongsun Mo, am willing to assist the Divine Venerable in resisting the demon clan."

Jin Yan, who had been silent, pondered for a long time before finally sighing and standing: "Very well. If the demon clan isn't eliminated, the six realms will never have a day of peace. The Jin Clan is willing to follow the Divine Venerable's commands and jointly cultivate the Waning Moon Array."

Jiang Li had one hand extended in mid-air, as if wanting to stop Chu Qingqiu, but Chu Qingqiu no longer looked at her, only staring expressionlessly at the closed palace doors.

She slapped the table hard, then had to slowly stand up, saying quietly: "The Jiang Clan is also willing."

Finally, everyone's eyes turned to Liu Wenhai, who remained seated. His face had turned green as he uncomfortably stroked his stubble.

Gongsun Mo smiled knowingly, as if he had expected this: "Divine Venerable, having the three of us is enough. As for certain others... we can do without them."

"Who says I'm unwilling? It was my daughter who was kidnapped by the demon clan!" Liu Wenhai stood up indignantly, his beard bristling. "It's just dealing with a mere demon clan - what is there to fear!"

"Good." Chu Qingqiu nodded, her glass hairpin swaying with her movement. She stood up again. "Since you are all willing to assist, I thank you all here."

With that, she suddenly bowed her head, that birch-like back that had always been straight bending down before several people, startling them so much they all jumped up.

What kind of cold and aloof person was Chu Qingqiu, who never concerned herself with worldly affairs? Usually, forget about bowing to others - she probably wouldn't even make small talk. So when the several family heads saw this, they were terrified enough to jump up and return the bow.

Only after Chu Qingqiu straightened up did they breathe a sigh of relief.

"The Divine Venerable truly honors us too much." Jin Yan covered her heart.

Chu Qingqiu rarely showed some smile as she lowered her head: "Since you have all agreed, you must stay in my Jingshan Palace for the next few days and cannot step out of the palace gates."

"Please don't overthink this. The Waning Moon Array matter is something I'm doing in secret - no one in the sect knows about it, to prevent word from leaking out. Later, I'll tell others that you've already left Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, to make the demon clan lower their guard and lure them out."

"We understand."

Seeing their agreement, Chu Qingqiu's constantly anxious heart finally relaxed somewhat. She had Qiuyi see the guests out, then called out to Jiang Li who was turning to leave.

"Medical Immortal Jiang." She spoke as she slowly walked forward, stopping in the wind outside the door.

"Divine Venerable." Jiang Li didn't look at her, only staring at her own feet, seeming not in high spirits. "Is the Divine Venerable really planning to perform the Waning Moon Array?"

Chu Qingqiu's red lips parted slightly, then she nodded: "Yes."

"But your body..." Jiang Li frowned and looked up. "Are you really not planning to live even this last year? With your physical condition driving the Waning Moon Array, even with assistance, how is that different? You'll still exhaust your immortal power, and if there are any other accidents, your meridians will be completely severed and you'll die in agony!"

"Though you are a Divine Venerable, there are so many people in this world - you don't need to shoulder every disaster." Jiang Li became more indignant as she spoke.

"Those with ability do more, those without do less - that's the principle of cultivation." Chu Qingqiu's voice was gentle, no longer cold and distant. "The demon clan has done so much - what they're after is definitely not just Ning Fuyi. There must be a greater conspiracy behind it. Since I still have the power to stop it, I have no reason not to act."

"Anyway, this life has only a few days left - let it die for a worthy cause."

"Divine Venerable, no matter how you put it, you still care about the young sect master. Have you considered that if you die, leaving her alone in this world, how much pain she'll suffer?"

"I have nothing to do with her. Her world doesn't only have me. Even if she grieves for me, after a hundred years pass, she won't remember anymore." Chu Qingqiu's words were like spring wind - as they blew, the corners of her eyes grew somewhat red.

She closed her eyes and continued: "If she doesn't remember, she won't suffer."

"You're even keeping this from her." Jiang Li shook her head repeatedly, somehow also reddening around the eyes. "Keeping her in the dark like this - aren't you afraid she'll hate you when she learns the truth?"

"Do you know what it feels like to be hated by your beloved..." Jiang Li couldn't continue, stopping to breathe several times before calming down slightly.

"In her heart, I probably should have died long ago." Chu Qingqiu said.

Chu Qingqiu's lips relaxed slightly. She said no more, instead changing the subject: "I only fear that after I die, there will truly be no one to protect her. The path ahead - I don't know how difficult it will be."

Jiang Li looked at her thin body wrapped in loose robes, then at her profile, finally unable to say anything. She reached out to adjust her shawl: "The Divine Venerable was asking about dual cultivation earlier, wasn't she?"

"Mo Qihuai sent word that she would arrive at Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate today. She should be here by now. I want the young sect master to receive her first."

"Don't worry, Divine Venerable. I invited Mo Qihuai here under the pretext of reminiscing about old times. No fifth person will know about the dual cultivation matter - it won't cause trouble for the young sect master. Since there's nothing more here, may I leave Jingshan Palace to see my junior sister? At least I need to inform her about the young sect master's condition."

Chu Qingqiu suddenly clenched her palm, as if frozen in place. After a while, she slowly nodded.

Jiang Li's gaze swept over Chu Qingqiu's hands hidden in her sleeves, immediately understanding. Then she deliberately said: "However, to have them dual cultivate, I'll need to tell Mo Qihuai the complete truth, including about that demonic tree."

"Though I feel this junior sister can be trusted, given the gravity of the matter, what does the Divine Venerable think..."

Chu Qingqiu's fingertips trembled slightly, as if some thought was colliding in her mind.

"I'll go see her first." she said softly.

Meanwhile, in a wooden house in a corner of Cloud Ascension Mountain, the atmosphere was quite strange.

Ning Fuyi and a woman in yellow robes sat facing each other, each with a cup of tea before them, silent.

Jiuying, equally confused, was leaning against a bamboo couch, alternately watching the two of them and idly tossing green dumplings into the air to watch Ping'an jump up and swallow them.

"Jiuying, could you go out and take Ping'an for a walk?" Finally, Ning Fuyi spoke first, giving Jiuying a meaningful look.

Jiuying lazily put down the green dumplings, gathered her white hair behind her, and smiled as she extended her hand toward Ning Fuyi.

Ning Fuyi took out a money pouch from her chest and tossed it to her. Jiuying caught it satisfactorily and was about to leave when Ning Fuyi grabbed her arm.

"Do you still remember what I asked you to investigate secretly?" Ning Fuyi said in her mind.

"What kind of person am I, Jiuying? A divine beast qilin! Finding some demonic energy and demon flowers - even Ping'an could do that. How could I mess up?" Jiuying winked at her, then turned and disappeared.

After she left, Ning Fuyi turned around and sat down again.

Footnotes:

¹ Waning Moon Array (残月阵) - A powerful formation technique that Chu Qingqiu used to defeat ancient evil spirits in the past, requiring multiple cultivators to perform and extremely taxing on the array's focal point